5E

THE LORD OF THE RINGS™ ROLEPLAYING

RULES

Based on *The One Ring™ Roleplaying Game* by Francesco Nepitello and Marco Maggi

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'This is the Master-ring, the One Ring to rule them all.'

— *The Fellowship of the Ring*™

It is the year 2965 of the Third Age and the Shadow is returning. Twenty-four years ago, an alliance of Elves, Men, and Dwarves defeated a horde of Orcs and Wild Wolves, inaugurating a new era of prosperity for the Free Peoples. But more than twenty years is a long time for peace to last, and in many dark corners of the Earth a shadow is lengthening once again.

Rumours of strange things happening outside the borders of civilised lands are spreading with increasing regularity, and while they are dismissed by most as fireside tales and children's stories, they sometimes reach the ears of individuals who recognise the sinister truth they hide.

These are restless warriors, curious scholars and wanderers, always eager to seek what was lost or explore what was forgotten. Ordinary people call them adventurers, and when they prevail, they hail them as heroes. But if they fail, no one will even remember their names…

This is *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying*, a stand-alone roleplaying game set compatible with 5E and based on *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*, two extraordinary works of fiction by the beloved author and respected academic, John Ronald Reuel Tolkien. With these books, Tolkien introduced readers to his greatest creation, the world of Middle-earth, a mythic land from a remote past.

With *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying*, Middle-earth is yours to explore — you will travel the land searching for clues about the return of the Shadow, and have the chance to play a part in the struggle against the Enemy.

THE TWILIGHT OF THE THIRD AGE

The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying is set in the time period between *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. Encompassing more than six decades, this period is ushered in when Bilbo the Hobbit finds the Ruling Ring, and culminates with the war fought by the Free Peoples against the Dark Lord Sauron, and the destruction of the Ring.

Players of *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* take the roles of a Company of heroes — Hobbits, Dwarves, Elves, and Men, seeking adventure in the Lone-lands of Eriador. It is a desolate country, a vast region that once saw the glory of the North Kingdom of the Dúnedain, the Men of the West. Here, many wars were fought, and countless ruins dot its landscape. Shadows move along its paths, and not all of them belong to the living.

It is in Eriador that the One Ring lies, dormant, a seed of the past that will one day bring the end of this age of the world.

Example of Play

Loremaster: *The sun begins to dip below the Misty Mountains, casting long shadows across the ruins of an ancient watchtower. You stand at the edge of the Trollshaws, and the air is thick with the scent of pine and earth. Ahead, an old stone path winds through the trees. What do you do?*

Duinhir (Ranger Warden): *I study the path ahead, trying to determine if it has been recently travelled. Could be useful to know if we're following in someone else's footsteps.*

Loremaster: *Make a Wisdom (Hunting) check, Difficulty Class 15.*

Duinhir (rolling dice): *I've exceeded the Difficulty Class! A success!*

Loremaster: *You notice faint footprints in the dirt that seem fresh — likely no more than a day old. They lead further into the forest, along the path.*

Mentha (Hobbit Treasure Hunter): *While Duinhir is at it, I check these ruins more closely. There could be something valuable or useful hidden among the stones.*

Loremaster: *Alright, make an Intelligence (Investigation) check.*

Mentha (rolling dice): *I rolled a ᚠ icon, an extraordinary success!*

Loremaster: *Well done! You find a rusted helm buried under some rubble. It's beyond repair, but as you lift it, something shiny catches your eye — a small, green gem rolled out from its hiding place. But as you lean closer, your ears catch the distant cracking of twigs...*

Mentha: *I look at Fimbrethil and silently direct her attention to the nearby trees.*

Fimbrethil (Elf Scholar): *Noticing Mentha's disquiet, I attune my senses to the forest, listening for any unusual sounds or signs of danger.*

Loremaster: *Go ahead and make a Wisdom (Perception) check.*

Fimbrethil: *I made it.*

Loremaster: *Your keen senses discern distinctly that a group is moving silently through the woods toward you. They might be stealthy, but not enough to escape Elven ears.*

Fimbrethil: *Good. I lean closer to Regin, saying softly 'We are not alone…'*

Regin (Dwarf Champion): *Well, let's not be caught unprepared then! I retreat into the thick undergrowth, to assume an advantageous position should enemies burst out of the trees.*

The short 'unfinished tale' above is an example of what can happen when playing *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying*. This is what is called a pen-and-paper roleplaying game, in which players take the roles of fictional heroes and go on adventures together. This game can be played with two to six players. All you need to play is this boxed set, some pencils, imagination, and a love for Tolkien's imaginary world.

THE CORE COMPENDIUM

This Starter Set includes five pregenerated Player-heroes and a full adventure to play, and gives players a taste of the game and the world. Once you are familiarized with the game, you are ready to take on the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* rules, and venture across the vast expanses of Eriador and beyond.

> *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core rules compendium, available separately, includes rules for creating your own Player-heroes, a range of dangerous Adversaries, a trove of information about the world of Middle-earth, and a host of other resources. Unlike this Starter Set, *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core compendium requires the 5E core books to play.

The Player-heroes

With the exception of the Loremaster (below), each player takes the role of a single Player-hero, a fictional character whose attributes are inspired by those of the protagonists of the stories by J.R.R. Tolkien. Together, the Player-heroes are referred to as the Company.

> This Starter Set is played using a Company of up to five pre-generated Player-heroes, ready-to-play characters setting the players on the road to adventure in no time.

To enter Middle-earth, players must simply step into their characters' shoes, trying to think as they would think and react as they would react. It is a game of make-believe, a story in the making, created in collaboration with the Loremaster.

The Loremaster

The Loremaster doesn't take the role of a single character, but is instead the player in charge of describing the setting and managing what happens to the Player-heroes when they interact with the game world.

The Loremaster begins each session of play by setting the scene, playing the parts of the people and creatures the characters encounter — called Loremaster characters or Adversaries, based on whether they are peaceful or hostile — and adjudicating the consequences of the Player-heroes' actions.

The ultimate goal of the Loremaster is to provide the premise for the creation of a new epic, focused entirely around the deeds of the Player-heroes.

ADVENTURING

'Even the good plans of wise wizards like Gandalf and of good friends like Elrond go astray sometimes when you are off on dangerous adventures over the Edge of the Wild…'

— The Hobbit™

The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying is played as a series of sessions, comparable to the chapters of a book. Usually, two or three sessions are played as part of a longer story, called an *adventure*. One such adventure, called *Over Hill and Under Hill*, is included in this Starter Set.

With the help of the adventure text, it is the job of the Loremaster to challenge the players, putting them in difficult circumstances, setting fiendish riddles for them to solve, and confronting them with formidable opponents.

The gameplay is a dynamic narrative, as the players take action to explore the situations they encounter. The Loremaster then describes what happens as a result of their actions, and the players again react to the new circumstances, and so on.

The Loremaster keeps the story flowing through a mixture of preparation and improvisation.

THE SESSION

An average adventure should occupy the Loremaster and the players for about two or three sessions of play, with each session clocking in at around three hours of gaming. Generally speaking, every single session tends to follow the same structure:

1. Introduction
2. Scenes
3. End of the Session

1. INTRODUCTION

If the session is the first one of an adventure, the Loremaster presents the current situation to the players. This usually sets a date or time of the year (*when*), a location (*where*), and defines an introductory situation (*what*) that includes information that allows for the involvement of the Company (*why*).

If it's not the first session of play, then the opening scene picks up from where the adventure broke off at the end of the previous session.

2. SCENES

Once a session has started, the gameplay transitions from one scene to another, with each scene describing a situation requiring the players to make meaningful decisions. Each scene can vary in duration from less than an hour of play time (a short but meaningful encounter), up to the entire length of the session.

3. END OF A SESSION

When the time allocated for the game session is up, the Loremaster and the players face two possible situations:

- If the session ends without the players reaching a satisfactory conclusion, the gameplay will resume at a later date with another session. When the playing group meets again, the Loremaster starts by summarising what happened in the previous one.
- If, on the contrary, the current narrative arc has reached its conclusion, the adventure is over. Time to plan for the next!

PLAYING SCENES

Story-building is a fundamental component of *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying*. But it isn't about hearing a story being told, but rather about creating it over the course of the game, as the result of the interaction at the gaming table between the Loremaster and the players.

A session of play is played as a series of scenes, connected sequentially in a wider narrative arc. A scene is a single episode focusing on the Company facing some kind of challenge, preparing for one, or recovering from it.

1. FRAME THE SCENE

To frame a scene, the Loremaster first describes the location where the action is taking place, and who is there. Then, the Loremaster defines the challenge that the Company is facing.

> When playing a pre-written adventure, such as *Over Hill and Under Hill* included in this Starter Set, the adventure text will help the Loremaster frame each scene.

2. THE PLAYERS REACT

Next, the players proceed to describe what actions their Player-heroes take to investigate and resolve the challenge facing them.

3. RESOLVE THE SCENE

The Loremaster evaluates the plan of the players, and adjudicates whether to just 'say yes' and grant them what they want to achieve, or ask for a die roll using the Ability Checks procedure described on page 9. Combat, Councils and Journeys have special rules described later in this booklet.

Player-Heroes

'… you have been chosen, and you must therefore use such strength and heart and wits as you have.'

— *The Fellowship of the Ring*™

All Player-heroes are defined in the game by a collection of traits and numbers, describing their physical, spiritual, and mental attributes, and the extent of their knowledge and capabilities.

The pre-generated Player-heroes included in this Starter Set each have a separate character sheet. The front of the sheet contains all the information, stats and the special traits of the character, while the back contains a quick description of their background and personality.

Culture and Calling

Each Player-hero belongs to a Culture and has a chosen Calling, both listed on the character sheet. These are mainly used when creating a Player-hero and are described in detail in the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core rules compendium.

Traits and Backgrounds: Each Culture has a number of cultural traits and virtues. The effects of these are described on the character sheets in this Starter Set. Any traits that affect numerical scores are already factored in.

Calling Features: Each Calling also provides a Player-hero with a set of unique features. These are described on the character sheets included in this Starter Set.

Shadow Path: A Player-hero's Calling determines their Shadow Path — the fate of the Player-hero if they fail to resist the Shadow's influence (page 12).

Abilities

There are six main Abilities in the game: Strength, Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma. These scores describe a Player-hero's fundamental physical, emotional, and mental capabilities. Abilities typically range from 3 to 18, but can go higher.

ABILITY MODIFIERS

The six ability ratings are used to determine a Player-hero's ability modifiers — the modifiers to any d20 roll made in an ability check when the Player-hero attempts an action. More on this later.

In this Starter Set, all ability modifiers are listed on the character sheets or, for Adversaries, in the adventure text.

THE PRE-GENERATED PLAYER-HEROES

All features, traits, and virtues for the pre-generated Player-heroes are explained on the character sheets (some on the back, for space). The effects are abbreviated, for use with this Starter Set. If you want to continue using these Player-heroes for further adventures, we recommend that you look up the full effects of these features, traits, and virtues in the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core compendium.

Level

All Player-heroes included in this Starter Set are at *level 1*. During the adventure included in this Starter Set, *Over Hill and Under Hill*, they have a chance to advance to level 2, improving their capabilities.

Proficiency Bonus: Player-heroes and Adversaries have a Proficiency Bonus determined by their level. The Proficiency Bonus is used for ability checks, attack rolls, and saving throws. The pre-generated characters in this Starter Set all have a Proficiency Bonus of +2.

LEVELLING UP

When a Player-hero levels up, two things happen:

- The Player-hero's Hit Point maximum increases by the roll of a Hit Die (page 6), modified by the Constitution modifier.
- The Player-hero gains new traits, features, or virtues, as indicated on the character sheet.

Further rules for experience are included in the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core rules compendium.

Distinctive Features

Distinctive Features describe aspects of a Player-hero's build or temper, personality traits or physical peculiarities. These features help players to picture their characters, and encourage deeper roleplaying.

> A Player who portrays their character's Distinctive Features might be awarded Inspiration (page 10) by the Loremaster.

SKILL PROFICIENCY

While each ability covers a broad range of capabilities, a skill represents a specific aspect of an ability. A Player-hero (or Adversary) can be proficient in skill, indicated by a mark in the checkbox by the skill on the character sheet.

> When a Player-hero is proficient with a skill, their Proficiency Bonus is added to the ability check.

The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying includes a set of 19 skills. Their use is described in detail in the core rules compendium. The adventure included in this Starter Set, *Over Hill and Under Hill*, states which skills to use and when.

WEAPON PROFICIENCY

Similarly to skills, a Player-hero or Adversary can be proficient with a certain type of weapon. All characters are assumed to be proficient with *simple weapons* such as clubs, daggers, and spears, while *martial weapons*, including swords, axes, and polearms, require individual proficiencies.

> When a Player-hero is proficient with a weapon, their Proficiency Bonus is added to the attack roll.

The pre-generated Player-heroes in this Starter Set all have their weapon proficiencies accounted for in the attack roll bonuses listed on their character sheets.

OTHER PROFICIENCIES

A Player-hero can also have proficiencies for saving throws, tools, and armour.

- **Saving Throw Proficiency:** Lets a Player-hero (or Adversary) add their Proficiency Bonus to saving throws (page 10) made using a particular ability. These are marked with checkboxes on the character sheet.
- **Tool Proficiency:** Lets a Player-hero add their Proficiency Bonus to any ability check using that tool.
- **Armour Proficiency:** A Player-hero wearing armour they lack proficiency with has Disadvantage on any ability check, saving throw, and attack roll using Strength or Dexterity.

DERIVED RATINGS

Each Player-hero has a number of derived ratings listed on their character sheet (or in the adventure text, for Adversaries). For the pre-generated Player-heroes in this Starter Set, these ratings are already filled in on the character sheets, with all special features and virtues accounted for.

HIT POINTS

A Player-hero's Hit Points represent a combination of physical and mental durability, the will to live, and luck. Creatures with more Hit Points are more difficult to kill in combat (page 15).

> A Player-hero's Hit Point maximum is determined by their Calling and Constitution modifier, and can be increased by cultural traits and virtues.

Hit Dice: A Player-hero's Hit Dice, also set by their Calling, determines how much they can heal when resting (page 17).

ARMOUR CLASS

The Armour Class of a Player-hero or Adversary determines how hard it is to hit in combat (page 14). It depends on the armour worn, in some cases modified by the Dexterity modifier as well as special features and virtues.

INITIATIVE MODIFIER

This rating is used in combat and is equal to the Dexterity modifier.

SPEED

The distance (in feet) the Player-hero can move in a round of combat, determined by their Culture. Note that this rating is not used in the abstracted combat rules (page 12) included in this Starter Set.

EQUIPMENT

All Player-heroes start the game equipped with the adventuring gear, armour, weapons, and tools based on their Culture and Calling. These starting items are listed on the character sheets in this boxed set. During the course of the game, Player-heroes may find more gear or acquire it by spending their starting wealth.

Equipment Lists: Lists of common equipment can be found on the following pages.

ENCUMBRANCE

A Player-hero's carrying capacity is equal to their Strength score multiplied by 15. This is the maximum weight (in pounds) that they can carry. However:

- A Player-hero who carries weight in excess of 5 times their Strength score is Encumbered, meaning they get a Disadvantage on Strength (Athletics) checks, Dexterity (Acrobatics) checks, and Fatigue saving throws (page 22).
- A Player-hero who carries weight in excess of 10 times their Strength score is Heavily Encumbered, meaning they have Disadvantage on ability checks, attack rolls, and saving throws that use Strength, Dexterity, or Constitution.

Push, Drag, or Lift: A Player-hero can temporarily push, drag, or lift a weight up to twice their carrying capacity (30 times the Strength score). While pushing or dragging weight in excess of the carrying capacity, a Player-hero cannot fight.

PATRON

Every Company of Player-heroes has a Patron, an influential individual who has taken an interest in the group, and that in the course of the game will offer the Company additional reasons to go adventuring. This is explained in the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core rules compendium. The pre-generated Player-heroes in this Starter Set have Gilraen, daughter of Dírhael, as their Patron.

COINAGE IN MIDDLE-EARTH

In north-western Middle-earth, most cultures engage in bartering to acquire the goods they need for their daily necessities. But since the death of the Dragon, trade has started to flourish once again, and coins have become more common, especially in those settlements that lie along the Dwarven trading routes from the Lonely Mountain to the Ered Luin.

Still, the coins that change hands are mainly silver pennies and copper coins. Gold pieces are very valuable and rare — the few still found in circulation come from the fabled treasure of Smaug the Dragon, and most people show an uncanny propensity to hoard them and hide them away.

EXCHANGE RATES

- 1 gold piece = 10 silver pennies
- 1 silver penny = 10 copper coins

> The following abbreviations are used in the game: g for gold piece; s for silver penny; and c for copper coin.

ADVENTURING GEAR

ITEM	COST	WEIGHT
Bag	2 s	5 lb.
Bedroll	1 s	7 lb.
Blanket	5 c	3 lb.
Book	25 s	5 lb.
Candle (set of 10)	1 c	–
Clothes, common	5 c	3 lb.
Clothes, fine	15 s	6 lb.
Clothes, traveller's	2 s	4 lb.
Lantern	5 s	2 lb.
Pole (10-foot)	1 c	7 lb.
Rope, hempen (50 feet)	1 s	10 lb.
Rope, silk (50 feet)	10 s	5 lb.
Sack	1 c	½ lb.
Tinderbox	5 c	1 lb.
Torches (bundle of 10)	1 c	10 lb.

ARMOUR

LIGHT ARMOUR	COST	ARMOUR CLASS	FATIGUE AND STEALTH	WEIGHT
Leather Shirt	10 s	11 + Dex mod. (max 4)	–	8 lb.
Leather Corslet	45 s	12 + Dex mod. (max 3)	–	10 lb.

MEDIUM ARMOUR	COST	ARMOUR CLASS	FATIGUE AND STEALTH	WEIGHT
Hide	10 s	12 + Dex mod. (max 2)	–	12 lb.
Mail-shirt	50 s	13 + Dex mod. (max 2)	–	20 lb.
Scale Armour	50 s	14 + Dex mod. (max 2)	Disadvantage*	40 lb.

HEAVY ARMOUR	COST	ARMOUR CLASS	FATIGUE AND STEALTH	WEIGHT
Ring-mail	50 s	15	Disadvantage*	50 lb.
Coat of Mail	75 s	16	Disadvantage*	55 lb.
Mail Hauberk	20 g	17	Disadvantage*	60 lb.

SHIELDS	COST	ARMOUR CLASS	FATIGUE AND STEALTH	WEIGHT
Shield	10 s	+2	–	6 lb.

* If an armour type indicates disadvantage, the wearer has disadvantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks and on Fatigue saving throws at the end of journeys (page 22)

WEAPONS

SIMPLE MELEE WEAPONS	COST	DAMAGE	PROPERTIES	WEIGHT
Axe	5 s	1d6 slashing	Versatile (1d8)	3 lb.
Club	1 c	1d4 bludgeoning	–	2 lb.
Club, Great	2 c	1d8 bludgeoning	Two-handed	10 lb.
Dagger	2 s	1d4 piercing	Finesse, thrown	1 lb.
Hammer	2 s	1d6 bludgeoning	–	3 lb.
Hatchet	5 s	1d6 slashing	Thrown	2 lb.
Spear	1 s	1d6 piercing	Thrown, versatile (1d8)	3 lb.
Staff	2 c	1d4 bludgeoning	Versatile (1d6)	2 lb.

SIMPLE RANGED WEAPONS	COST	DAMAGE	PROPERTIES	WEIGHT
Bow	25 s	1d6 piercing	Two-handed	2 lb.

MARTIAL MELEE WEAPONS	COST	DAMAGE	PROPERTIES	WEIGHT
Axe, Battle	10 s	1d8 slashing	Versatile (1d10)	4 lb.
Axe, Great	30 s	1d12 slashing	Two-handed	7 lb.
Hammer, Heavy	10 s	1d8 bludgeoning	Versatile (1d10)	4 lb.
Mattock	10 s	1d12 piercing	Two-handed	10 lb.
Spear, Great	20 s	1d10 piercing	Two-handed	6 lb.
Sword	15 s	1d6 slashing	Finesse, versatile (1d8)	2 lb.
Sword, Long	20 s	1d8 slashing	Versatile (1d10)	3 lb.
Sword, Short	10 s	1d6 piercing	Finesse	2 lb.

MARTIAL RANGED WEAPONS	COST	DAMAGE	PROPERTIES	WEIGHT
Great Bow	50 s	1d8 piercing	Two-handed	3 lb.

TOOLS

ITEM	COST	WEIGHT
Carpenter's tools	8 s	6 lb.
Cartographer's tools	15 s	6 lb.
Cook's utensils	1 s	8 lb.
Leatherworker's tools	5 s	5 lb.
Mason's tools	10 s	8 lb.
Smith's tools	20 s	8 lb.
Herbalism kit	5 s	3 lb.
Flute	2 s	1 lb.
Harp	30 s	2 lb.

ITEM	COST	WEIGHT
Horn	3 s	2 lb.
Navigator's tools	25 s	2 lb.
Pipes	1 s	½ lb.
Thieves' tools	25 s	1 lb.

SMOKING PIPES

A Player-hero proficient with Pipes can spend an hour smoking to gain Inspiration (page 10). They cannot use a Pipe again in this way until they finish a Long Rest.

Ability Checks

'Of the various burglarious proceedings he had heard of, picking the trolls' pockets seemed the least difficult…'

— *The Hobbit™*

A game session takes the form of a continuous conversation between the Loremaster and the players, who collaborate in bringing to life a series of scenes in which the Player-heroes are the protagonists.

> The main way for the players to participate in a scene is simply to tell the Loremaster *what* their Player-heroes are doing, and *how* they intend to do it. In game terms, this is called *taking an action*.

When to Make a Check

An ability check tests a Player-hero's (or Adversary's) innate talent and training in an effort to overcome a challenge. The Loremaster should only call for an ability check if there is a possibility that the chosen action might fail — if not, the action succeeds automatically.

> Pre-written adventures, such as *Over Hill and Under Hill* included in this Starter Set, typically state when an ability check is required. However, the Loremaster may always call for one if the situation warrants it.

Difficulty Class

For every ability check, the Loremaster (or the adventure text) decides which of the six abilities is relevant to the task at hand and the difficulty of the task, represented by a Difficulty Class (DC). The more difficult a task, the higher its DC. The adjacent table shows the most common DCs.

TYPICAL DIFFICULTY CLASSES

TASK DIFFICULTY	DC
Very easy	5
Easy	10
Medium	15
Hard	20
Very Hard	25
Nearly Impossible	30

Making the Check

To make an ability check, roll one of the twenty-sided dice included in this boxed set — called a d20 — and add the relevant ability modifier. If you're using a skill or weapon, use the bonus listed on the character sheet. Certain Features and Traits might add bonuses or penalties to the roll.

> For Player-heroes, the ᚠ symbol means 20, the best possible result, and the 👁 symbol means 1, the worst possible roll. For Adversaries, the symbols are reversed — the 👁 means 20 and the ᚠ means 1.

Compare the total to the DC. If the total equals or exceeds the DC, the ability check is a success — the Player-hero overcomes the challenge at hand. Otherwise, it's a failure, which means the Player-hero makes no progress toward the objective or makes progress combined with a setback determined by the Loremaster (or the adventure).

Passive Checks

A *passive check* is a special kind of ability check that doesn't involve any die rolls. Such a check can represent the average result for a task done repeatedly or can be used when the Loremaster wants to secretly determine whether the Player-heroes succeed at something without rolling dice, such as noticing a hidden Adversary.

> The score of a passive check is 10 + all applicable modifiers. If the Player-hero has Advantage on the check, add 5. For Disadvantage, subtract 5.

THE LORD OF THE RINGS ROLEPLAYING DICE

The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying uses the normal set of polyhedral dice used in 5E — from 4-sided (d4) to 20-sided (d20), and a set of such dice are included in this Starter Set. However, on the d20, the 1 side is replaced by the 👁 symbol and the 20 side is replaced by the ᚠ symbol. These symbols can trigger special effects in the rules.

SAVING THROWS

A saving throw — also called a save — represents an attempt to resist a disease, poison, trap, or other threat. The Loremaster or the adventure determines when to make a saving throw, which ability to use, and what the Difficulty Class is.

> To make a saving throw, roll a d20 and add the appropriate ability modifier. If the total equals or exceeds the DC, the saving throw succeeds.

A saving throw can be modified by a situational bonus or penalty and can be affected by Advantage and Disadvantage, just like ability checks.

Proficiency: As with skill proficiencies, proficiency in a saving throw lets a Player-hero add their Proficiency Bonus to saving throws made using a particular ability. Some Adversaries have saving throw proficiencies as well.

ADVANTAGE AND DISADVANTAGE

Sometimes the circumstances give a Player-hero Advantage or Disadvantage on an ability check, attack roll, or saving throw.

> When this happens, roll a second d20 when you make the roll. Use the higher of the two rolls if you have Advantage, and the lower roll if you have Disadvantage.

If multiple situations affect a roll and each one grants Advantage or imposes Disadvantage, don't roll more than one additional d20. If circumstances cause a roll to have both Advantage and Disadvantage, they cancel each other out and just a single d20 is rolled.

INSPIRATION

Inspiration is a rule the Loremaster can use to reward a player for playing their Player-hero in a way that's true to their character — specifically their Distinctive Feature (page 4). A Player-hero either has Inspiration or does not — they can't stockpile multiple "inspirations" for later use.

> A player can expend Inspiration when making an ability check, attack roll, or saving throw. Doing so gives them Advantage on the roll.

Shadow

'And that is another reason why the Ring should be destroyed: as long as it is in the world it will be a danger even to the Wise. For nothing is evil in the beginning.'

— *The Fellowship of the Ring*™

Challenging an almost all-powerful Enemy and facing its terrible minions is bound to instil a sense of fear and doubt in the Player-heroes, a sentiment that in time comes to weigh heavily on their hearts and minds. This burden is represented by the accumulation of Shadow Points.

How many Shadow Points a particular event potentially inflicts is indicated in the *Over Hill and Under Hill* adventure, and is explained in detail in the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core compendium. Shadow Points are tracked on the character sheet.

Shadow Saving Throw

When exposed to Shadow, a Player-hero may make an Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma saving throw (depending on the source of Shadow) to resist it.

> When a saving throw against Shadow is successful, the Player-hero reduces the number of Shadow Points gained by 1. If the saving throw succeeds by 5 or more, the number of Shadow Points gained is reduced by 2.

Sources of Shadow

Player-heroes gain Shadow in many ways, and the source of Shadow determines which ability is used for the saving throw. See the adjacent table.

MISDEED

Player-heroes gain Shadow Points if they commit an act that is wrong or nefarious in nature, regardless of the objective they are trying to achieve. See the adjacent table for examples.

> A Misdeed is a special instance of Shadow gain, as no saving throw is allowed to resist it. The Loremaster should usually warn the players when they are about to carry out a Misdeed.

Consequences of Shadow

When the number of Shadow Points accumulated by a Player-hero matches or exceeds half their Wisdom score (rounded up), they become Miserable.

> If a Miserable character rolls an 👁 or a 2 in any ability check, attack roll, or saving throw, the roll fails automatically.

A Player-hero whose Shadow score reaches the full value of their Wisdom score also becomes Anguished.

> An Anguished character has Disadvantage on all ability checks, attack rolls, and saving throws.

SOURCES OF SHADOW

SOURCE	DESCRIPTION	ROLL FOR
Dread	Witnessing distressing events or facing terrible foes.	Charisma
Greed	Taking possession of precious or powerful objects.	Wisdom
Sorcery	Fall victim of dark magics.	Intelligence
Misdeed	Committing despicable actions.	No Save

MISDEEDS

DEED	SHADOW POINTS
Violent threats and malicious lies, heedless cruelty	1
Manipulating others, abusing authority, deliberate cruelty	2
Theft or plunder, oathbreaking or cowardice, treachery	3
Torment or torture, killing or crippling a surrendered foe or harmless folk	4

MADNESS

To get rid of Shadow Points, a Player-hero must play out a bout of madness — a violent outburst or crisis that frees a Player-hero from the burden of the Shadow, but may have serious consequences.

> To play a bout of madness, the player should describe how their Player-hero loses control for a short period of time and does something they will later regret, taking into account the source of the last Shadow gain, the Player-hero's Shadow Path, or a Flaw (below).

After a bout of madness, all Shadow Points and their effects are removed, but the Player-hero advances one step along their Shadow Path.

SHADOW PATH

In addition to resetting their Shadow score, every time a Player-hero suffers a bout of madness they advance along their Shadow Path, each time acquiring a specific Flaw — a Distinctive Feature with a negative connotation.

Flaws: If a Player-hero makes an ability check that can plausibly be affected by a flaw, the check has Disadvantage.

Succumbing to the Shadow: If a Player-hero's Shadow score reaches their full Wisdom score for a fifth time, they are taken out of play. This is beyond the scope of this Starter Set and is explored in the full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* rules.

COMBAT

'There was a ring and clatter as the Company drew their swords.'

— *The Fellowship of the Ring*™

Should a fight erupt between Player-heroes and their Adversaries, it is played out using the combat diagram and cardboard stand-up figures included in this Starter Set.

> Note that these combat rules are an abstracted and simplified version of the full 5E combat rules, for faster gameplay. Full 5E combat rules can be used with the *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core compendium.

COMBAT SEQUENCE

Once combat is initiated, the following steps should be followed to keep the action flowing:

1

DETERMINE RANGE

The Loremaster determines the distance between the Player-heroes and their adversaries at the start of combat:

- **Extreme (up to 300 feet):** Only Great Bows can be used at this range, and then with Disadvantage.
- **Long (up to 100 feet):** Great Bows can be used at this range without Disadvantage, and normal Bows with Disadvantage.
- **Short (up to 30 feet):** All Ranged and Thrown weapons can be used without Disadvantage.
- **Engaged (5 feet):** Melee weapons can be used.
- **Note:** The indicated distances in feet above are only used for estimation.

2

OPENING VOLLEYS

If the distance between the Player-heroes and their adversaries is Short or more, both sides are allowed an opening volley. Each combatant with a ranged weapon with sufficient range may make an attack with it. Normally, a volley exchange is resolved with the Player-heroes launching their volleys first, unless the Loremaster considers the circumstances to favour the opposition.

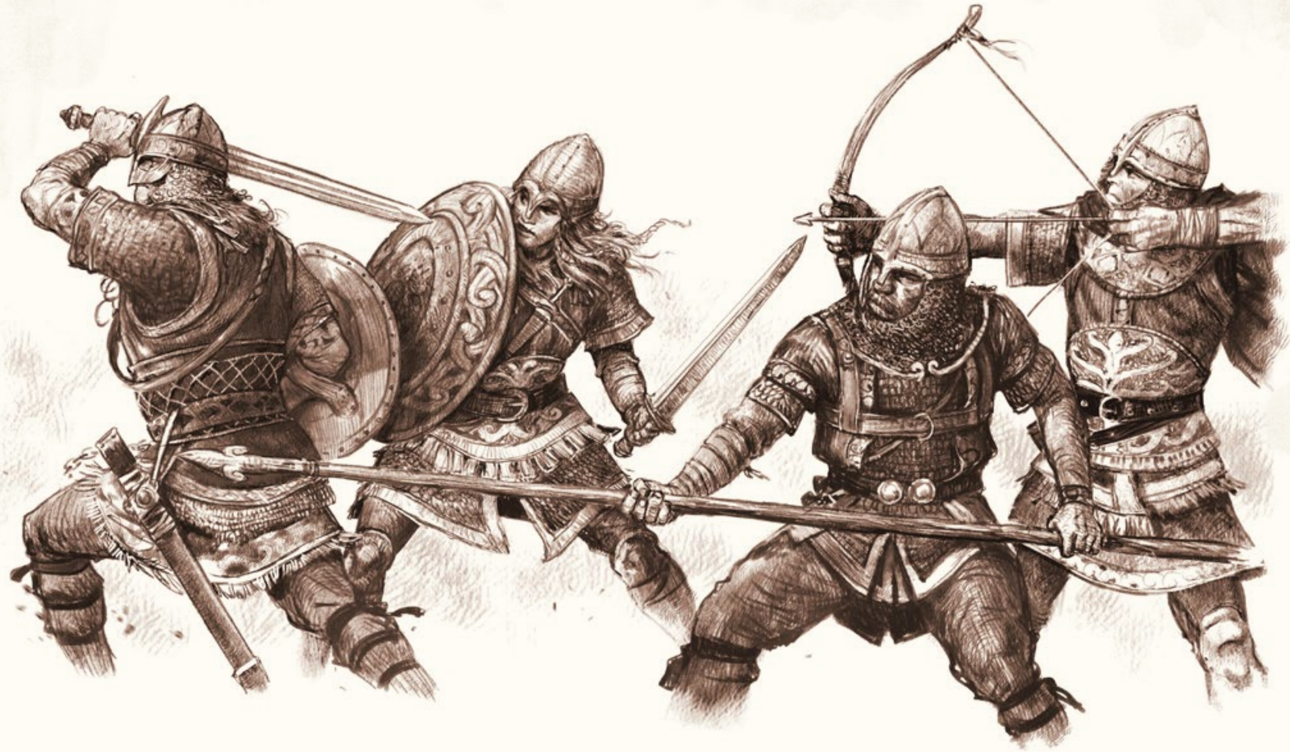
Closing In: After the opening volley, the distance between the Player-heroes and their adversaries is decreased by one category. If the distance remains Short or more, another volley is made, and again until the distance is reduced to Engaged.

3

CHOOSE STANCES

When at Engaged range, each Player-hero chooses their stance for the round. There are three Close Combat stances (Forward, Open, and Defensive) and one Ranged Combat stance (Rearward).

- **Forward:** The Player-hero is being reckless and aggressive. They have Advantage on all attack rolls, and all attack rolls against them have Advantage. A Player-hero in Forward stance can take the Intimidate Foes action.
- **Open:** The Player-hero is being cautious, striking when they can while keeping their guard up. Attack rolls are made as normal. A Player-hero in Open stance can take the Rally Comrades action.



Forward Stance

Open Stance

Defensive Stance

Rearward Stance

- **Defensive:** The Player-hero is being careful and protecting themselves extensively. They have Disadvantage on all attack rolls, and attack rolls against them have Disadvantage. A Player-hero in Defensive stance can take the Protect Companion action.
- **Rearward:** The Player-hero stays away from the press of the fighting to attack their foes from a distance. The Player-hero can only attack with, and be attacked by, Ranged weapons. A Player-hero is allowed to assume a Rearward stance only if the total number of enemies isn't more than twice the number of Player-heroes in the Company. Furthermore, for each Player-hero in the Rearward stance, there must be two other Player-heroes fighting in Close Combat stances. A Player-hero in Rearward stance can take the Prepare Shot action.

Mark Stances: Place the cardboard stand-ups representing the Player-heroes anywhere on the circles on the combat diagram corresponding to their chosen stances.

4 ENGAGEMENT

All Player-heroes in Close Combat stances (not Rearward) must engage one or more adversaries.

If there are *more enemies than Player-heroes* at the beginning of the round, engagement is handled by the Loremaster as follows:

1. The Loremaster assigns one opponent to each unengaged Player-hero fighting in a Close Combat stance.
2. For each remaining foe, the Loremaster chooses between engaging a Player-hero in a Close Combat stance who is already engaged, or standing back to attack any Player-hero using any Ranged weapon.

If there are *more Player-heroes than enemies*, or their number is tied, at the beginning of the round, engagement is chosen by the players as follows:

1. Each Player-hero in a Close Combat stance chooses an unengaged adversary to face. If there are more Player-heroes in Close Combat than foes, several Player-heroes may engage the same enemy.
2. If one or more of the Company is fighting in Rearward stance, it is possible that there will be enemies left when everyone fighting in Close Combat has engaged an adversary. If this happens, the Loremaster chooses whether the 'spare' enemies engage a Player-hero who is already fighting in a Close Combat stance, or stand back to attack with a Ranged weapon.

Mark Engagement: Place the cardboard stand-ups for adversaries in contact with the Player-hero with which they are engaged, or on the 'Foes Standing Back' circle if they are not engaged. If several Player-heroes in different stances are engaged with the same enemy, place all of their stand-ups on the same red 'slice' of the combat diagram to indicate engagement.

Unengaged Player-heroes: If a Player-hero who was engaged in Close Combat finds themself unengaged when their turn comes — if their main adversary has been killed by another Player-hero's attack — the Player-hero is free to choose another adversary to attack in Close Combat.

5

PLAYER-HERO ACTIONS

The actions of all combatants are resolved, with the Player-heroes going first, in stance order from Forward to Rearward. Player-heroes in the same stance can act in any order. Each Player-hero may perform an attack roll (below) or one special action for their stance:

- **Intimidate Foes (Forward Stance):** The Player-hero makes a DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) check. All foes who lose the contest are Frightened of the Player-hero until the start of the next round, meaning they have Disadvantage on all ability checks and attack rolls while the Player-hero remains in the fight.
- **Rally Comrades (Open Stance):** The Player-hero makes a DC 15 Charisma (Performance) check. On a success, all Player-heroes engaged in Close Combat gain Advantage on their next attack roll if it is made before the end of the next round.
- **Protect Companion (Defensive Stance):** The Player-hero nominates another Player-hero in a Close Combat stance. The next attack roll against the protected Player-hero is made with Disadvantage, if it is made before the end of the next round.
- **Prepare Shot (Rearward Stance):** The Player-hero gains Advantage on their next ranged attack if it is made before the end of the next round.

6

ADVERSARY ACTIONS

When it is the enemies' turn to act, the Loremaster chooses their actions, again in stance order (using the stance of the Player-hero they are attacking). The actions of enemies who stood back unengaged to attack with ranged weapons are resolved last.

7

START A NEW ROUND

Unless either side has been defeated, start a new round by again choosing stances (step #3 above), and proceed from there. An engaged Player-hero cannot choose to engage a different enemy until the current enemy has been defeated.

ATTACK ROLLS

The most common action in combat is to make an attack roll, such as swinging a Mattock in Close Combat, or firing a Great Bow in Rearward. Attacks at an engaged target (page 13) are *melee attacks*, while using a Ranged weapon is a *ranged attack*. To make an attack roll:

1. **Choose a Target.** A Player-hero In a Close Combat stance can make a melee attack against any target they are Engaged with, or the Loremaster judges is within easy reach (for example, a wooden door to a fortified outpost). A Player-hero in Rearward stance can select any target in the combat for a ranged attack. A Ranged weapon can be used in Close Combat, but the attack roll has Disadvantage.
2. **Determine Modifiers.** The Loremaster determines if any penalties or bonuses apply, and if the attack roll has Advantage or Disadvantage. The two most common

FLY, YOU FOOLS!

Player-heroes facing insurmountable odds and intending to leave the fight have two options:

- They can first assume a Rearward stance, and then choose to escape when their turn to act comes. No roll is required to do so. The same applies to adversaries who chose to stand back and thus remained unengaged.
- They can assume a Defensive Stance, and then make a DC 15 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check instead of attacking. If the check is successful, they manage to leave the battlefield. If the check fails, the combatant remains engaged.

OTHER ACTIONS

Players may propose to do something different from an attack roll, something unusual or unexpected — this is usually a sign that they are enjoying the game, and the Loremaster should encourage it wherever possible.

The two main factors to consider when resolving actions other than attack rolls are time and consequences. Can the Player-hero perform the action in one round, or will it take more time? A round is considered to last a maximum of 30 seconds. Does the action require a die roll? If so, success or failure must have clear consequences.

DON'T COUNT ARROWS

In this Starter Set, you don't need to count ammunition. Simply assume that Player-heroes and Adversaries with bows have enough arrows to cover their needs.

modifiers to the roll are an ability modifier and the attacker's Proficiency Bonus. The ability modifier used for melee weapons is Strength (except for weapons with the *finesse* property, for which Strength or Dexterity can be used) and the ability modifier used for ranged weapons is Dexterity. When an Adversary makes an attack roll, it uses whatever modifier is provided in its stat block.

3. **Resolve the Attack.** Roll a d20 (or two, if the attack has Advantage or Disadvantage) and apply the modifiers. If the total equals or exceeds the target's Armour Class, roll for damage (below), unless another effect applies. Some attacks cause other effects in addition to damage.

CRITICAL HITS

If a Player-hero rolls a ᚠ in an attack roll, the attack hits automatically and its damage dice are rolled twice (below). The same happens if an Adversary rolls a 👁. This is called a Critical Hit. Conversely, if a Player-hero rolls a 👁 — or an Adversary rolls a ᚠ — the attack misses automatically.

ONE OR TWO HANDS

Some weapons require two hands to use, and have the *two-handed* property. Weapons with the *versatile* property can be used with one hand, but do more damage if wielded with two. A weapon used two-handed cannot combined with a shield.

THROWN WEAPONS

A melee weapon with the *thrown* propery can be used for a ranged attack, but retrieving it requires a full action. A thrown weapon uses the same ability modifier as when it's used for a melee attack.

UNARMED STRIKES

Instead of using a weapon to make a melee weapon attack, a character can use an unarmed strike: a punch, kick, headbutt, or similar forceful blow. All characters are proficient with unarmed strikes. On a hit, an unarmed strike deals Bludgeoning damage equal to 1 + the Strength modifier.

Damage

Each weapon and Adversary ability specifies the damage it inflicts on a hit. Roll the damage dice, add the attacker's ability modifier (the same one used in the attack roll), and reduce the target's Hit Points by the total. It's possible for an attack to cause zero damage, but never negative damage.

Critical Hit: On a Critical Hit (ᚠ for Player-heroes, 👁 for Adversaries), roll the attack's damage die twice and add the results together. Then add the ability modifier once.

TEMPORARY HIT POINTS

Some features and virtues can give a Player-hero Temporary Hit Points, allowing them to temporarily increase their Hit Point maximum. The Temporary Hit Points last until they are depleted or the Player-hero finishes a Long Rest.

DAMAGE TYPES

Different attacks deal different types of damage. Damage types have no rules of their own, but other rules, such as Resistance, rely on them. The most common types of damage are Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing.

RESISTANCE & VULNERABILITY

Some Adversaries and items are difficult or particularly easy to damage with certain damage types. Resistance causes the damage inflicted to be halved (round down), while Vulnerability causes the damage to be doubled. These modifiers are applied after all other modifiers, but multiple instances of Resistance or Vulnerability only count as one instance. Multiple instances of Resistance or Vulnerability that affect the same damage type count as only one instance.

ZERO HIT POINTS

A Player-hero who drops to zero Hit Points is either dead or unconscious, as explained below. Negative Hit Points are not counted.

INSTANT DEATH

If the damage inflicted brings the target to zero Hit Points and there is damage remaining that equals or exceeds the Player-hero's Hit Point Maximum, they are killed outright.

FALLING UNCONSCIOUS

If a Player-hero is reduced to zero Hit Points but not killed, they fall unconscious, unable to move or take any actions. Unconsciousness ends when the Player-hero regains any Hit Points.

ADVERSARIES AND DEATH

Most Adversaries die the instant they drop to zero Hit Points and don't make Death Saves. Important Adversaries can be treated just like Player-heroes however, with the Loremaster making Death Saves for them.

DEATH SAVING THROWS

Whenever a Player-hero starts their turn with zero Hit Points, they must make a special saving throw, called a Death Save, to determine whether they creep closer to death or hang onto life. Unlike other saving throws, this isn't tied to any ability score. A Death Save succeeds on a roll of 10 or higher. On a 9 or lower, it fails.

> A success or failure on a Death Save has no effect by itself, but on the third success, the Player-hero is Stable (below). On the third failure, the Player-hero dies.

The successes and failures don't need to be consecutive — track both on the character sheets until there are three of a kind. The number of both is reset to zero when the Player-hero regains any Hit Points or becomes Stable.

> In a Death Save, rolling a 👁 counts as two failures. Rolling a ᚠ immediately makes the Player-hero stable.

STABILIZING A PLAYER-HERO

A Player-hero making Death Saves is immediately stabilized and stops making Death Saves if they recover any Hit Points. The Player-hero can also be stabilized by a DC 10 Wisdom (Medicine) check, but remains unconscious at zero Hit Points, and must start making Death Saves again if they suffer any further damage.

> A stable Player-hero automatically regains 1 hit point after 1d4 hours. For healing beyond that, see *Resting* (page 17).

HEALING

Some Player-heroes (and Adversaries) have special features to heal themselves or others. When a character receives healing, the Hit Points regained are added to its current amount. The total Hit Points can never exceed the character's Hit Points maximum.

RESTING

Player-heroes can take two types of breaks to recover from their adventures:

- **Short Rest:** A Short Rest lasts for about an hour, and allows each Player-hero to spend one or more Hit Dice, adding their Constitution bonus to each die roll, regaining Hit Points equal to the total result.
- **Long Rest:** A Long Rest usually represents a night's sleep, and allows the Player-heroes to recover all lost Hit Points. They also regain spent Hit Dice, up to a number equal to half of the Player-hero's total number (minimum of one). A Long Rest in a sheltered refuge (not 'on the road') also allows all Player-heroes to cancel one level of Exhaustion (page 24).

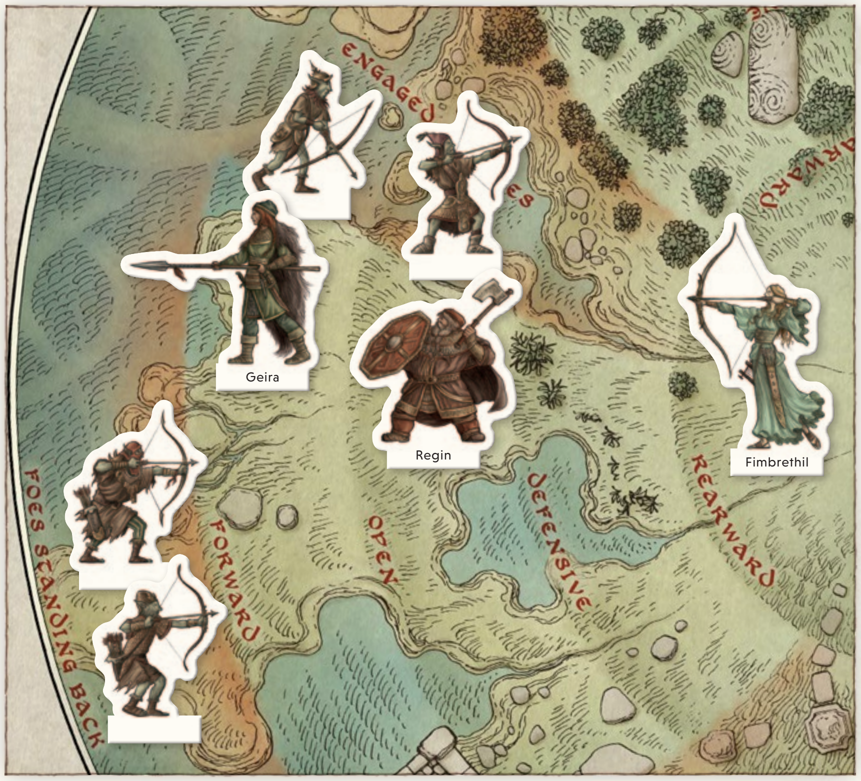
COMBAT EXAMPLE

Geira, Regin and Fimbrethil are facing five Goblin Archers in combat.

1. **Opening Volleys:** The initial range is Short, so there is only time for one opening volley for each side. Of the Player-heroes, only Fimbrethil has a ranged weapon. She fires an arrow with her Bow, rolling a ᚠ on the d20 — a Critical Hit! She rolls 2d6 for damage and adds her +2 ability modifier to the result for a total of 11 points of damage — enough to kill the Goblin outright.

   Next, the remaining four Goblin Archers all fire their Bows of Horn. One hits Regin and rolls a 3 on the d6 for damage. Adding +2 for the Goblin's ability modifier means the hit reduces Regin's current Hit Points by 5.
2. **Stances:** Now, Close Combat commences. Geira chooses Forward stance, Regin Open stance, and Fimbrethil Rearward stance — allowed since there are two Player-heroes in Close Combat stances and the Goblins don't outnumber the Company by more than two-to-one. The cardboard stand-ups for the Player-heroes are placed on the corresponding circles on the combat diagram.
3. **Engagement:** As there are more enemies than Player-heroes, the Loremaster assigns one Goblin each to Geira and Regin, while two stand back. One Goblin stand-up is placed next to Geira in the Forward circle, one next to Regin in the Open circle, and two in the 'Foes Standing Back' circle.
4. **Player-hero Actions:** Geira goes first, as she is in Forward stance. She swings her sword at the Goblin, gaining Advantage to her roll, and hits for 6 points of damage. Next, it's Regin's turn. He hits for 10 points of damage, knocking the Goblin down to zero Hit Points. Fimbrethil in Rearward stance fires an arrow at a Goblin standing back, hitting for 7 points of damage — not enough to slay the Goblin.
5. **Adversary Actions:** The Goblin engaged with Geira strikes back with his Jagged Knife, gaining Advantage for Geira's Forward stance and scoring a hit and reducing Geira's Hit Points by 4. The remaining Goblins standing back let loose their arrows at Fimbrethil and hit for 5 points of damage.

Thus, the first round of combat is over and another begins. The Player-heroes have the upper hand, but the fight is not over yet…



COUNCIL

'You will soon hear all you wish to know,' said Gandalf.
'We shall have a Council, as soon as you are well enough.'

— *The Fellowship of the Ring*™

Player-heroes meet many travellers and wanderers along the road. When the Company meets one or more Loremaster characters to discuss or negotiate something of importance, a Council occurs. Note that these rules don't need to be used for every verbal exchange however — everyday circumstances are better represented using a simple ability check.

> To achieve their goal in a Council, the Company must achieve a number of successful ability checks based on the import of the request and ranging from 1 to 3.

COUNCIL SEQUENCE

A Council is set up and resolved applying the following steps:

1 SET REQUIRED SUCCESSES

Before the Council begins, the players should all agree on what the Company hopes to achieve from the meeting.

> The difficulty for the Company to achieve their stated goal determines the number of successes required during the Interaction stage, and it is set by the Loremaster at a value of 1 (a reasonable request), 2 (a bold request), or 3 (an outrageous request).

AWARDING ROLEPLAYING

If a speech delivered during a Council touches topics that are relevant to the Company's goal and are deemed important by the audience, then the Loremaster can allow the Player-heroes to gain an Advantage on one or several ability checks.

2 INTRODUCTION

At the beginning of a Council, a spokesperson, chosen by the Company, makes a DC 15 Charisma check.

> On a success, the Company can reroll one failed check during the Interaction. On a Success by 5 or more, the Company can reroll two failed checks. On a failure by 5 or more, the Player-heroes get a Disadvantage on all checks during the Interaction.

The spokesperson can choose which skill to use, bearing in mind the following considerations:

- **Intimidation** conveys power briefly, but also exposes the Company's lineage, deeds, and other details to impress the Council.
- **Persuasion** relies on smooth talking to ease the Company's request to the Council and allows the spokesperson to politely refuse to reveal too much.
- **Deception** allows the Company to be careful about what they reveal, but is sure to engender mistrust on a failure.

3 INTERACTION

During this stage, the players engage with the Loremaster in playing out the scene, and make ability checks. The Loremaster modifies the rolls depending on the attitude of the audience:

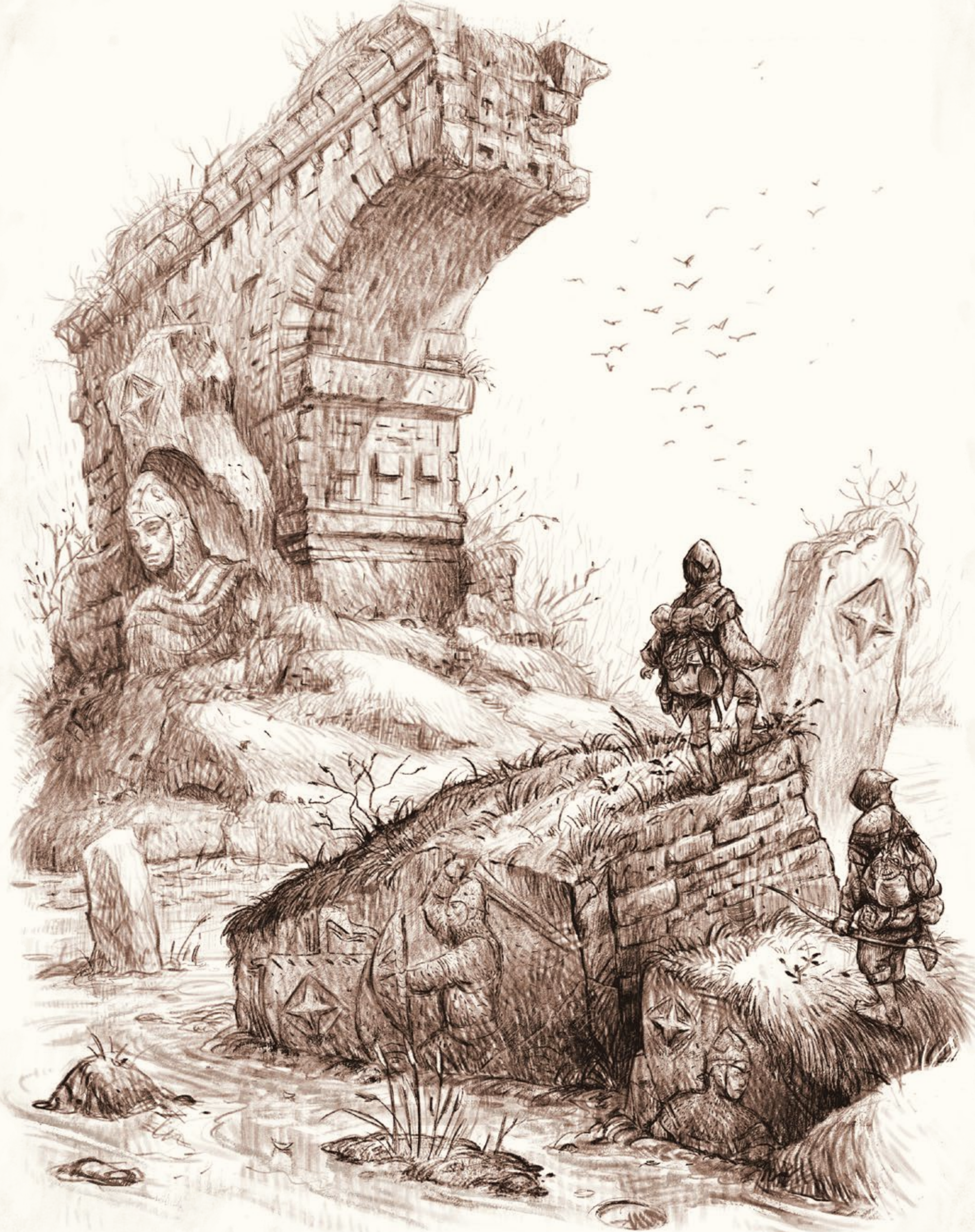
- **Reluctant:** DC 20
- **Open:** DC 15
- **Friendly:** DC 10

The Player-heroes can take turns in making ability checks in any way they like, using the skills Deception, Intimidation, Performance, Persuasion, Riddle, or Insight, depending on the situation and how they present themselves. The only exception is that the same Player-hero may not roll twice in a row for the same skill — either the Player-hero or the skill must be changed between each roll.

End of a Council

A Council can end in three different ways:

- All of the required ability checks succeed — the Player-heroes achieve what was chosen as their objective at the start of the Council.
- A Player-hero fails an ability check during the Interaction stage (after any rerolls gained by a successful Introduction) — the Player-heroes can now choose to simply fail, and be refused what they asked for, or, with the approval of the Loremaster, they can opt to achieve their stated goal, but at a price.
- A Player-hero fails an ability check during the Interaction stage by 10 or more (after any rerolls), or by 5 or more if the request was outrageous — The Company is now seen as a threat by the folk encountered.



JOURNEY

'He then gave a full account of their journey from the time when they left Hobbiton.'

— *The Fellowship of the Ring™*

A Company will often end up travelling across long leagues of inhospitable and unfamiliar areas in the course of their errands and quests. A Journey requires the following tools, all included in this Starter Set:

- A player map of the traversed area, such as the large Eriador map in this boxed set.
- A Loremaster map with 20-mile hexagons (included in the *Over Hill and Under Hill* adventure).
- A Journey log (also available for download from the Free League website).

THE TRAVELLING COMPANY

The members of the Company assume different roles during a Journey. The roles summarise what each Player-hero is doing for the length of the trip, which comes into play when the Company experiences an event (below).

> There are four Journey roles to cover: Guide, Hunter, Look-out, and Scout.

Assigning Roles: The Company must cover all four roles. If there are more than four Company members, multiple Player-heroes can be assigned the same role — with the exception of the Guide (there can be only one Guide). Conversely, if the Company counts less than four Player-heroes, then one or more adventurers will have to take on the duty of multiple roles.

JOURNEY ROLES

ROLE	FUNCTION
Guide	In charge of all decisions concerning route, rest, and supplies
Hunter	In charge of finding food in the wild
Look-out	In charge of keeping watch
Scout	In charge of setting up camp, opening new trails

JOURNEY SEQUENCE

Journeys are resolved by applying the following sequence:

1

SET JOURNEY PATH

Using the player map, the Company shows the Loremaster the route that they intend to follow to their destination.

> When tracing their Journey path, the players must consider that their itinerary can rarely be drawn 'as the crow flies.' Instead, due consideration must be given to the lie of the land.

For example, high mountain ranges and swift-running rivers can be traversed only across passes or over bridges or fords.

> Then, the Loremaster checks the Loremaster map and draws the Company's itinerary on a copy of the Journey log, using its hex grid, as a path traversing a number of hexes equal to those required to reach the destination (not counting the starting hex). Each hex represents approximately one day's travel.

2 MAKE WISDOM (TRAVEL) CHECKS

Journeys can be dangerous, as a travelling Company experiences along the way a number of events representing threats and unexpected occurrences.

> Events take place in specific spots along the Journey path of the Company. To determine exactly where, the Guide of the Company must make a DC 15 Wisdom (Travel) check.

As soon as the Company leaves, the Guide makes a first Wisdom (Travel) check, and counts a number of hexes along the Journey path based on the outcome of the check:

- If the Wisdom (Travel) check was a failure, the event occurs 2 hexes away along the Journey path. If the check fails by 5 or more, the event occurs only 1 hex away.
- If the Wisdom (Travel) check was a success, the event takes place at a distance of 3 hexes. If the check succeeds by 5 or more, the event occurs 4 hexes away.

The Loremaster finds the precise spot by counting the appropriate number of hexes, starting from the current position of the Company and proceeding towards its destination. Mark the event on the Journey log.

> To determine the precise nature of an event, see the procedure described under *Event Resolution* (below).

Once the event has been resolved, the Guide makes a new Travel check to see if another event happens further along the Company's Journey path.

3 ENDING THE JOURNEY

A Journey continues until the Guide's marching test result matches or exceeds the number of hexes left between the Company's current position and their point of arrival — when this happens, the Company has reached its destination and the Journey is over.

Fatigue Saving Throw: At the end of the Journey, each Player-hero must make a DC 10 Constitution saving throw. The DC is increased by an amount determined by the number and the type of events faced by the Company (see table on page 24). Some types of armour give Disadvantage to the roll.

> If the Fatigue saving throw fails, the Player-hero suffers one level of Exhaustion (page 24). If the saving throw fails by 5 or more, the Player-hero suffers two levels of Exhaustion instead. If it fails by 10 or more, the Player-hero suffers three levels of Exhaustion instead.

See page 24 for the effects of Exhaustion and how to recover from it.

EVENT RESOLUTION

Once the Loremaster has identified the location where an event is going to take place, follow the steps below to resolve it.

1 SELECT TARGETS

The Loremaster selects who will face the Journey event by rolling a d6 on the adjacent table. The table identifies the possible targets among those Player-heroes covering the roles of Scouts, Look-outs and Hunters. The table also shows the ability check that will be required.

EVENT TARGET

d6	TARGET	ABILITY CHECK
1–2	Scout	Wisdom (Explore)
3–4	Look-out	Wisdom (Perception)
5–6	Hunter	Wisdom (Hunting)

2 DETERMINE EVENT

To determine the nature of the event, the Loremaster checks the map to see in which Region type the event is taking place, and then rolls a d20:

- Within a Border Land, the roll is made with an Advantage.
- Within a Wild Land, the roll is made normally.
- Within a Dark Land, the roll is made with a Disadvantage.

The roll result is then checked on the *Journey Events table* on page 24.

3

RESOLVE THE EVENT

To resolve the event, a Player-hero covering the indicated role must now make the ability check specified in step 1. If multiple Player-heroes cover the same role, the Company decides who rolls. The DC depends on the terrain in the hex where the event takes place:

- **Road:** DC 10
- **Open Terrain:** DC 15
- **Hard Terrain:** DC 20

Consequences: Each entry in the *Journey Events table* specifies what happens if the ability check fails or succeeds. In addition, almost all events additionally cause the DC of the Fatigue saving throw made at the end of the journey to increase.

DESCRIBING JOURNEY EVENTS

Journey events should be played out as short scenes describing what is happening to the Company, based on the information that the event resolution system has provided. The full *The Lord of the Rings Roleplaying* core compendium expands on this, and the adventure *Over Hill and Under Hill* in this Starter Set suggests some specific scenes to use.

EXHAUSTION

Journeys and some environmental hazards can lead to a condition called Exhaustion, measured in six levels. See the adjacent table. If an already exhausted Player-hero suffers another effect that causes Exhaustion, their current level of Exhaustion increases by the specified amount.

> A Player-hero suffers the effect of its current level of Exhaustion as well as all lower levels. For example, a Player-hero suffering level 2 Exhaustion has its Speed halved and has Disadvantage on ability checks.

Finishing a Long Rest in a safe refuge (page 17) reduces a creature's Exhaustion level by 1.

JOURNEY EVENTS

d20	EVENT	CONSEQUENCES
👁	Terrible Misfortune	The Fatigue saving throw DC increases by +3. Also, if the ability check fails, the target is reduced to half of their Hit Point Maximum (round up).
2–3	Despair	The Fatigue saving throw DC increases by +2. Also, if the ability check fails, everyone in the Company gains 2 Shadow Points, resisted by a DC 15 Charisma saving throw.
4–6	Ill Choices	The Fatigue saving throw DC increases by +2. Also, if the ability check fails, everyone in the Company gains 1 Shadow point, resisted by a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw.
7–14	Mishap	The Fatigue saving throw DC increases by +1. Also, if the ability check fails, the DC increases by +2 instead, and the length of the Journey increases by 1 day.
15–17	Short Cut	The Fatigue saving throw DC increases by +1. Also, if the ability check succeeds, reduce the length of the journey by 1 day, to a minimum of 1 day.
18–19	Chance-meeting	The Fatigue saving throw DC increases by +1. If the ability check succeeds, the DC does not increase, and the Loremaster improvises an encounter that favours the Company.
ᚠ	Joyful Sight	If the ability check succeeds, everyone in the Company gains Inspiration (page 10).

EXHAUSTION

LEVEL	EFFECT
1	Disadvantage on ability checks
2	Speed halved
3	Disadvantage on attack rolls and saving throws
4	Hit Point maximum halved
5	Speed reduced to 0
6	Death

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TYPICAL DIFFICULTY CLASSES

TASK DIFFICULTY	DC
Very easy	5
Easy	10
Medium	15
Hard	20
Very Hard	25
Nearly Impossible	30

SOURCES OF SHADOW

SOURCE	DESCRIPTION	ROLL FOR
Dread	Witnessing distressing events or facing terrible foes.	Charisma
Greed	Taking possession of precious or powerful objects.	Wisdom
Sorcery	Fall victim of dark magics.	Intelligence
Misdeed	Committing despicable actions.	No Save

MISDEEDS

DEED	SHADOW POINTS
Violent threats and malicious lies, heedless cruelty	1
Manipulating others, abusing authority, deliberate cruelty	2
Theft or plunder, oathbreaking or cowardice, treachery	3
Torment or torture, killing or crippling a surrendered foe or harmless folk	4

JOURNEY ROLES

ROLE	FUNCTION
Guide	In charge of all decisions concerning route, rest, and supplies
Hunter	In charge of finding food in the wild
Look-out	In charge of keeping watch
Scout	In charge of setting up camp, opening new trails

EVENT TARGET

d6	TARGET	ABILITY CHECK
1–2	Scout	Wisdom (Explore)
3–4	Look-out	Wisdom (Perception)
5–6	Hunter	Wisdom (Hunting)

JOURNEY EVENTS

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EXHAUSTION

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2	Speed halved
3	Disadvantage on attack rolls and saving throws
4	Hit Point maximum halved
5	Speed reduced to 0
6	Death